Project Proposal

CS206 Software Product Management

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Project Title: Focus or Else (FoE)

Headline/Elevator Pitch

Focus or Else (FoE) is a social accountability app that helps students follow through on their goals by pairing commitment with fair, pre-agreed consequences. By turning responsibility into a shared game rather than a solo struggle, FoE helps students build discipline and develop healthier, more consistent habits.

Problem worth solving

Most students start their semester with high ambitions, but good intentions often crumble when faced with the daily friction of procrastination. While productivity apps exist, they typically rely on self-discipline which is exactly what students are struggling with in the first place. So here are the problems that our app aims to address:

The "Solo Struggle" Trap: Existing habit trackers are private. When a student fails a goal in isolation, there are zero stakes and no one to notice, making it easy to hit "snooze" on their responsibilities.

The High-Pressure Environment: Between heavy project-based curriculums and the high cost of living, students face immense pressure. Procrastination doesn't just hurt grades; it wastes time that could be spent on part-time jobs or social well-being.

Lack of Immediate Stakes: Long-term goals (like passing an exam in three months) feel abstract. Without a near-term consequence for missing a study session today, students struggle to prioritize consistency over instant gratification.

Social Isolation in Productivity: Studying is often seen as a lonely chore. There is no platform that effectively merges the social connectivity students crave (like Instagram or Telegram) with the discipline they need to succeed.

Focus or Else (FoE) bridges this gap by transforming accountability from a private burden into a shared social game. By introducing "pre-agreed consequences" and peer verification, we turn vague intentions into tangible commitments, helping students build discipline through social skin-in-the-game rather than willpower alone.

Users/Target Market

Our primary users are full-time tertiary and university students in Singapore, aged 17-25. This includes local students balancing heavy project-based curriculums and international students navigating the high-pressure Singaporean academic environment.

- Collaborative accountability: Friends are well-positioned to hold one another accountable, allowing FoE to integrate naturally into existing social relationships.

- Mobile-first connectivity: Students rely on platforms such as Telegram and Instagram for communication and information sharing. Embedding accountability into these digital spaces ensures that interventions are immediate and highly visible to peer networks.

- Reputation-driven behaviour: FoE transforms personal accountability into a shared social experience, where visibility and peer perception reinforce consistent follow-through.

Idea/Solution

FoE is a social accountability engine that helps people follow through on their goals by pairing light social pressure with playful consequences. It transforms responsibility into a shared game rather than a solo struggle.

How It Works

- Users can create a Pact, which consists of:
- Task: e.g., “Study calculus for 2 hours.”
- Deadline: Today, 8:00 PM – 10:00 PM.
- Verification Type: Photo, Video, Live Check, or an AI-generated summary/reflection of the work.

Pact Management

- Active Limits: Users are limited to a specific number of active Pacts at once (e.g., 3 active Pacts).
- History: Completed or resolved Pacts (where the consequence was served) are stored in the user’s history.

Verification Modes

- Friend (The "Foe"): A human verifier. Even when using AI tools for the initial check, the friend has the final say in confirming completion. The deadline remains strict; as long as the user submits their proof on time, the friend's review time does not count against them.

- AI Referee: An automated first pass for "solo" Pacts. The AI verifies both task completion and consequences. Note: AI verification is limited to tasks that can be clearly captured via photo or video.

Social Features

- FoE is a social-first app. It features a "For You" page (similar to Instagram) where users can track their friends' progress.
- Integrated Consequences: To protect privacy, consequences involving photos, text, or social media-style posts are handled directly within the FoE app rather than on external platforms like Facebook or Instagram.
- Profile & Stats: Each user has a dedicated profile displaying their consistency and success rates.

In-App Currency: Coins

- To avoid the legal and ethical risks of real-money gambling, FoE uses an internal currency:
- Earning: Users earn coins by completing tasks. The payout scales with the difficulty of the task.
- Spending: Coins can be used to "buy" more creative, pre-defined consequences to set for friends. Harder consequences cost more.
- Rewards: Currency can also be redeemed for real-world vouchers (e.g., Grab, Foodpanda).

Stakes and Consequences

- The user or their friend sets a stake or consequence from a list of allowed categories. These only trigger if the task is not completed by the deadline.
- Safety First: All consequences are pre-defined by the app to ensure they remain ethical, legal, and private. Some pre-defined consequences are listed in the section ahead.
- Virtual Stakes: Stakes involve the in-app currency rather than real money.

Why It Works

Public Commitment + Immediate Consequences = Loss Aversion

- Because responsibilities are shared publicly, the "social cost" of failing creates healthy pressure. While many tasks (like tidying a bed) lack immediate negative effects, FoE provides an immediate consequence to discourage procrastination. The app doesn't replace willpower; it reinforces it through competition and social stakes.

Choosing the Consequence Ahead of Time Makes It Feel Fair

- This works because of "Pre-commitment." When you set a consequence while you are in a rational, "cold" state, you are more likely to choose a stake that is meaningful. By the time the deadline arrives and you feel lazy (a "hot" state), you cannot argue that the punishment is unfair because you were the one who agreed to

it when you were thinking clearly. This eliminates the "internal bargaining" that usually leads to failure.

Consequences Ideas

The "Social Blunder" (Feed-Based)

These are posted automatically (or must be posted) to the user's FoE followers.

- **The Public Apology:** The user must post a video saying, *"I let my inner sloth win today. [Friend's Name] is my superior in every way."*
- **Unfiltered Confession:** Example, the user must post a photo of their most cluttered/messy drawer or room.
- **The "Roast Me" Prompt:** The AI generates a playful, mildly roasting caption about the user's failure, and the user must post it with a selfie.
- **The Fan Club:** The user must post a 50-word "tribute" post praising their friend's productivity.

The "Effort Tax" (Action-Based)

These require physical or mental effort to resolve the Pact.

- **The Fitness Penalty:** Record a video doing 20 push-ups or a 1-minute plank. (AI can verify the movement/timer).
- **The Hand-Written Note:** Write *"I will not procrastinate"* 20 times on paper and upload a photo.
- **The Knowledge Check:** The AI gives a 5-question quiz on a random, boring topic (e.g., "History of the Paperclip"), and the user must get 100% to resolve the consequence.

The "Wallet Hit" (In-App Currency)

Since there is a coin system, these consequences directly impact their "wealth" or their currency.

- **The Redistribution:** A set amount of the user's coins is transferred directly to the Friend/Foe.
- **The Burn:** A portion of the user's coins is "burned" (deleted from the economy) as a penalty.
- **The Voucher Freeze:** The user is barred from redeeming coins for real-world vouchers (Grab/Foodpanda) for the next 48 hours.

The "Profile Shame" (Status-Based)

These affect how the user appears to the community.

- **The "Chicken" Badge:** A small "Failure" or "Sloth" icon appears on the user's profile for 3 days.

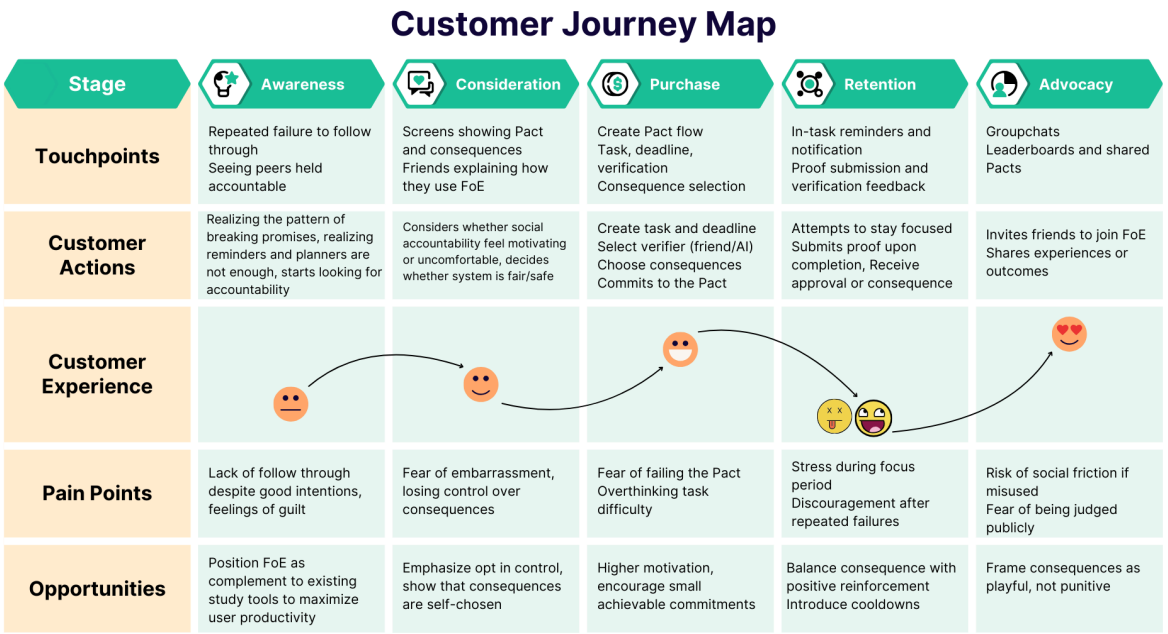
- **The Blackout:** The user’s profile picture is replaced by a "Default Procrastinator" avatar until their next successful Pact.
- **The Streak Breaker:** The user's "Consistency Score" is halved instantly.

The "Silly/Witty" (Playful)

- **The Lyricist:** The user must record themselves singing the chorus of a cheesy pop song.
- **The Bad Fashion Statement:** Post a photo wearing the most "mismatched" outfit currently in their closet.
- **The AI Puppet:** The user must let the AI write their "Bio" for the next 24 hours.

Persona/User Journey/Storyboard/Wireframes

Figure 1. Persona Diagram in relation to problem, user, and idea/solution



Customer Journey Map

Stage	Awareness	Consideration	Purchase	Retention	Advocacy
Touchpoints	Repeated failure to follow through Seeing peers held accountable	Screens showing Pact and consequences Friends explaining how they use FoE	Create Pact flow Task, deadline, verification Consequence selection	In-task reminders and notification Proof submission and verification feedback	Groupchats Leaderboards and shared Pacts
Customer Actions	Realizing the pattern of breaking promises, realizing reminders and planners are not enough, starts looking for accountability	Considers whether social accountability feel motivating or uncomfortable, decides whether system is fair/safe	Create task and deadline Select verifier (friend/AI) Choose consequences Commits to the Pact	Attempts to stay focused Submits proof upon completion, Receive approval or consequence	Invites friends to join FoE Shares experiences or outcomes
Customer Experience					
Pain Points	Lack of follow through despite good intentions, feelings of guilt	Fear of embarrassment, losing control over consequences	Fear of failing the Pact Overthinking task difficulty	Stress during focus period Discouragement after repeated failures	Risk of social friction if misused Fear of being judged publicly
Opportunities	Position FoE as complement to existing study tools to maximize user productivity	Emphasize opt in control, show that consequences are self-chosen	Higher motivation, encourage small achievable commitments	Balance consequence with positive reinforcement Introduce cooldowns	Frame consequences as playful, not punitive

Figure 2. Customer reaction and behavior interacting with the solution

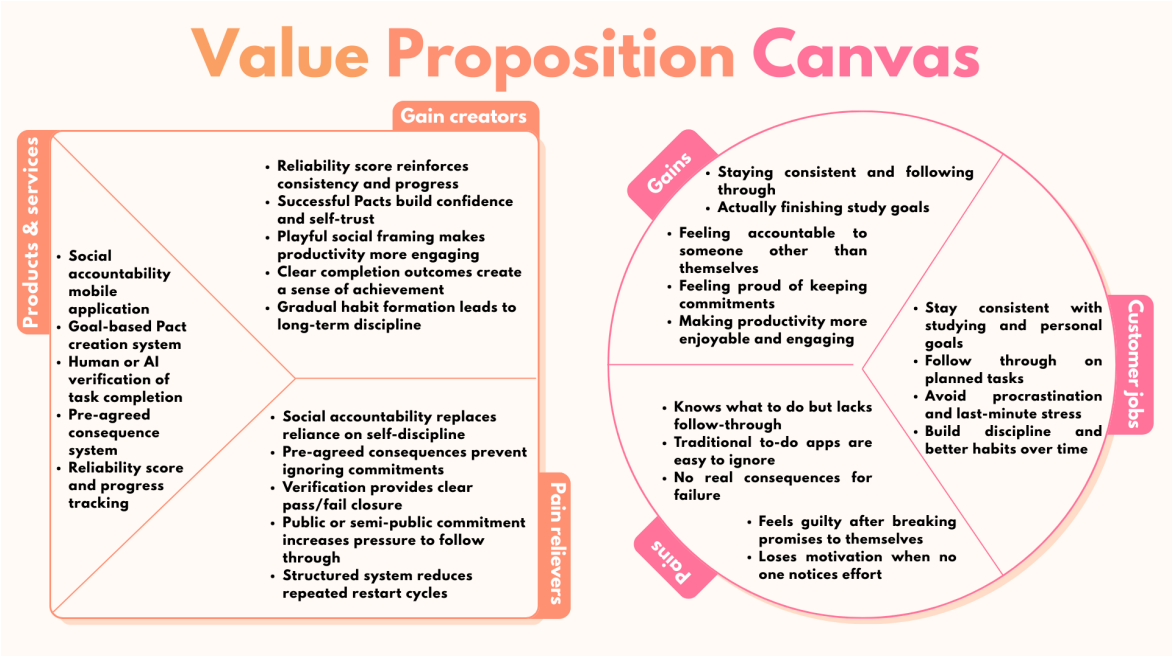


Figure 3. Value proposition canvas of the FoE

Early UI Concept (Subject to Iteration)

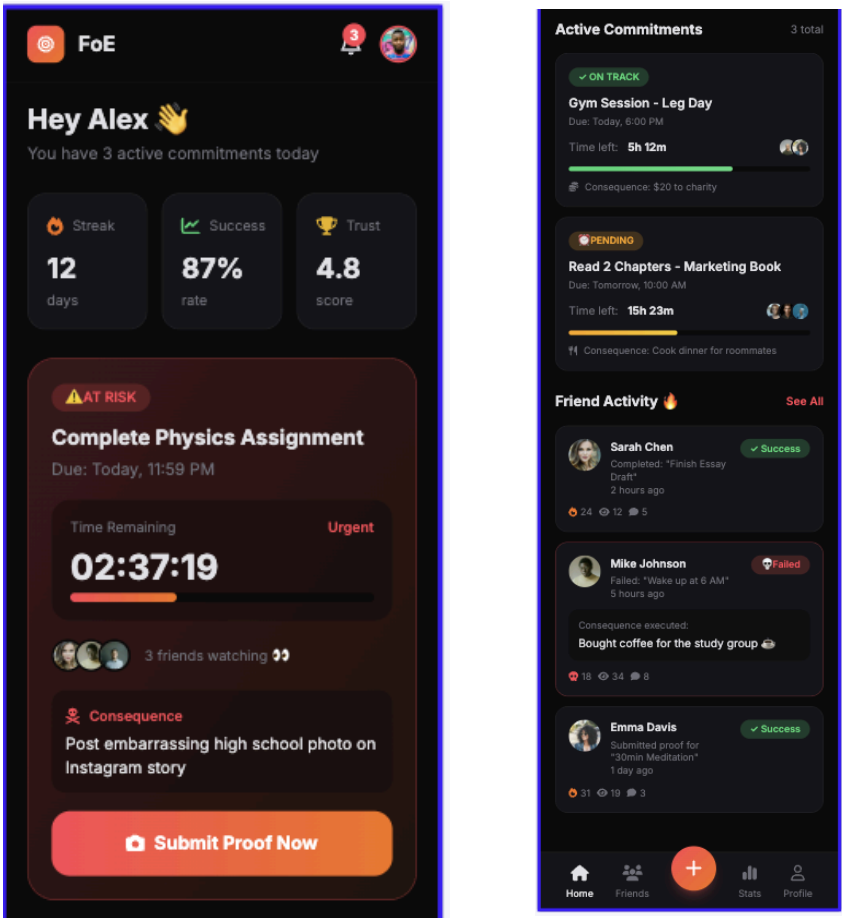


Figure 4. Home page design (Scrollable)

To better communicate the proposed solution and validate feasibility, we developed an early high-fidelity UI concept. This design is not final, but serves to illustrate how social accountability, time pressure, and pre-agreed consequences could be translated into a usable product experience.

Preliminary Analysis

Desirability

To evaluate user interest and desirability, an initial survey was done and sent mostly to our target market. The questions in the survey included:

1. How often do you struggle to stay consistent with habits such as studying, exercising, or reading?
2. What currently motivates you the most to stay consistent? (Select all that apply)
3. Would having friends hold you accountable increase your consistency with habits
4. How comfortable would you be with sharing habit progress with friends?
5. Do you find gamified systems (points, streaks, challenges, leaderboards) motivating?

6. Would real consequences (e.g. fun social penalties, small donations, light physical tasks) motivate you to complete tasks?
7. Which types of consequences would you find acceptable? (Select all that apply)
8. How likely would you be to use this type of app (a gamified accountability app with social enforcement and consequences)?
9. What would make you more likely to use this type of app?

Below is the summary of the responses for each question:

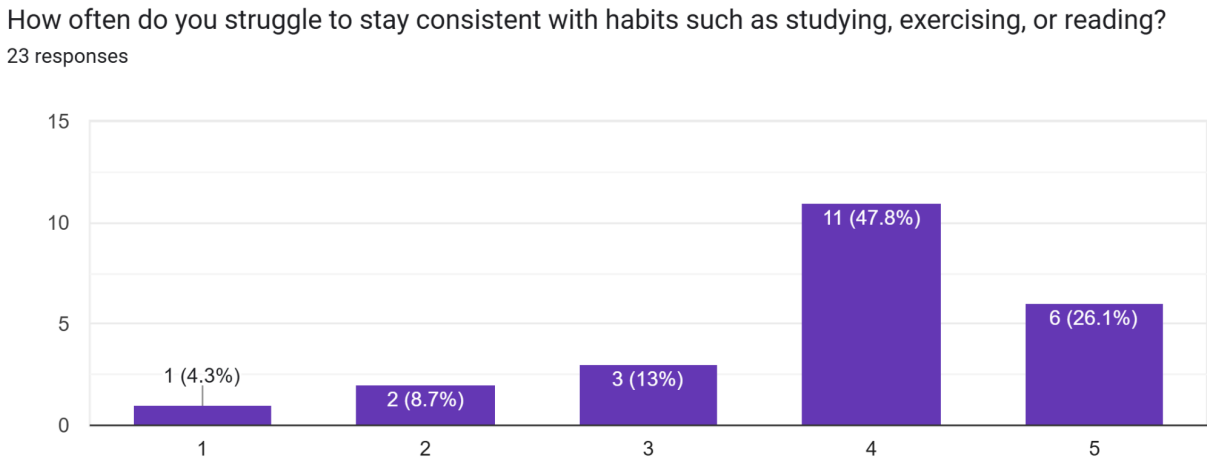


Figure 5. Survey result on staying consistent with habits

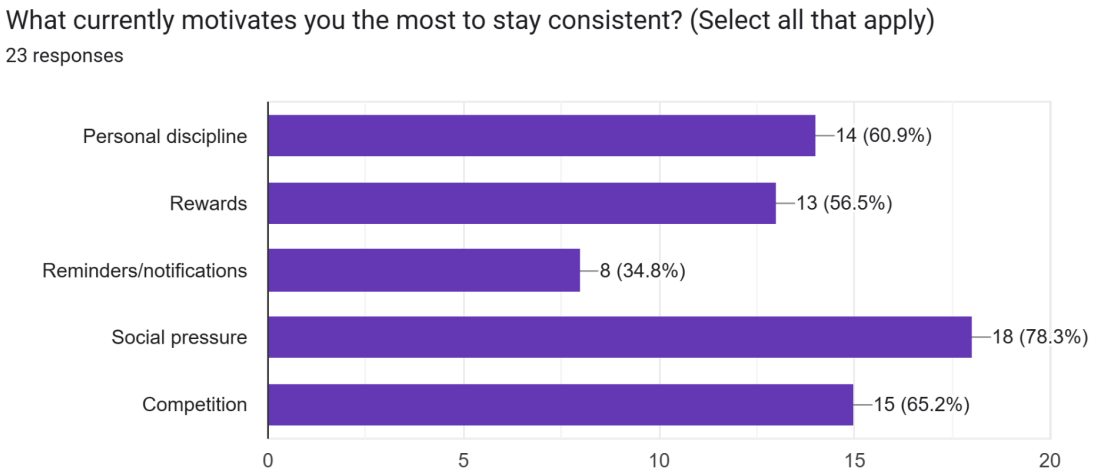


Figure 6. Survey results on what motivations push people to stay consistent

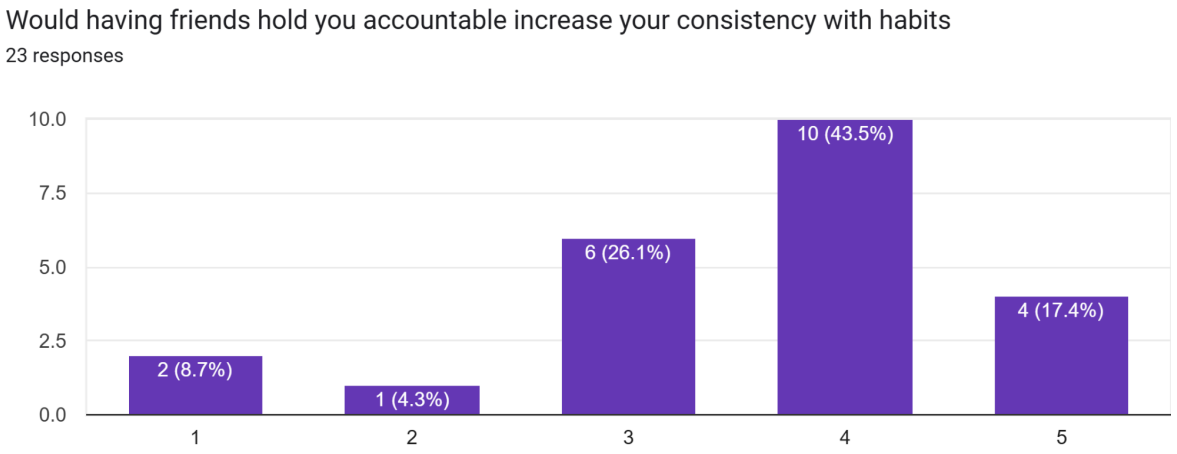


Figure 7. Survey result on the impact of friends in your accountability

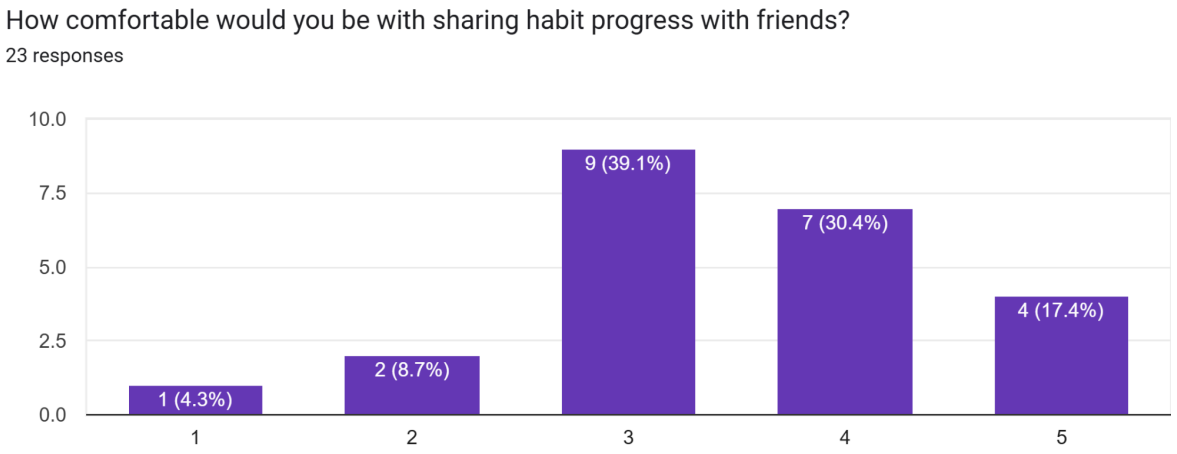


Figure 8. Survey results on how comfortable are people to share habit progress with friends

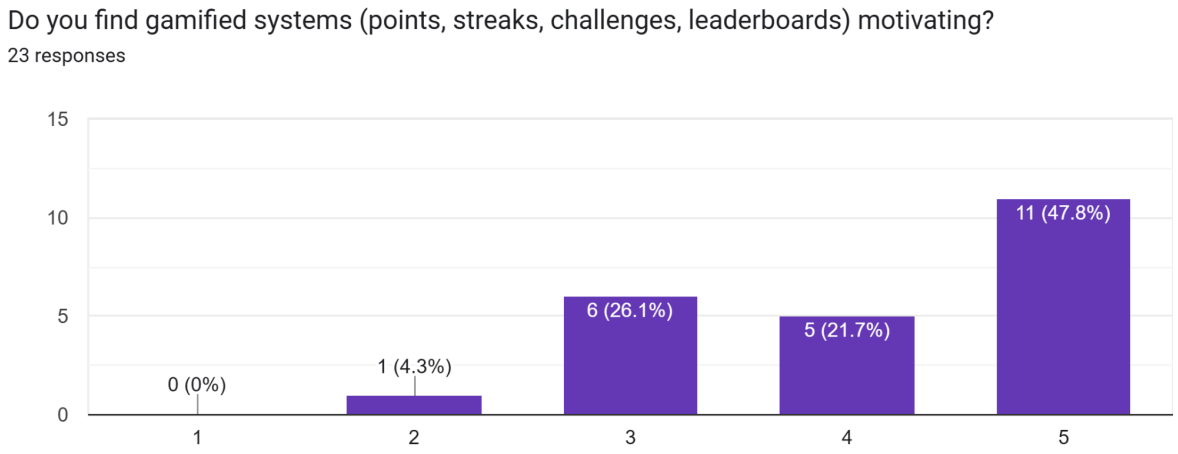


Figure 9. Survey result on whether they find gaming systems motivating

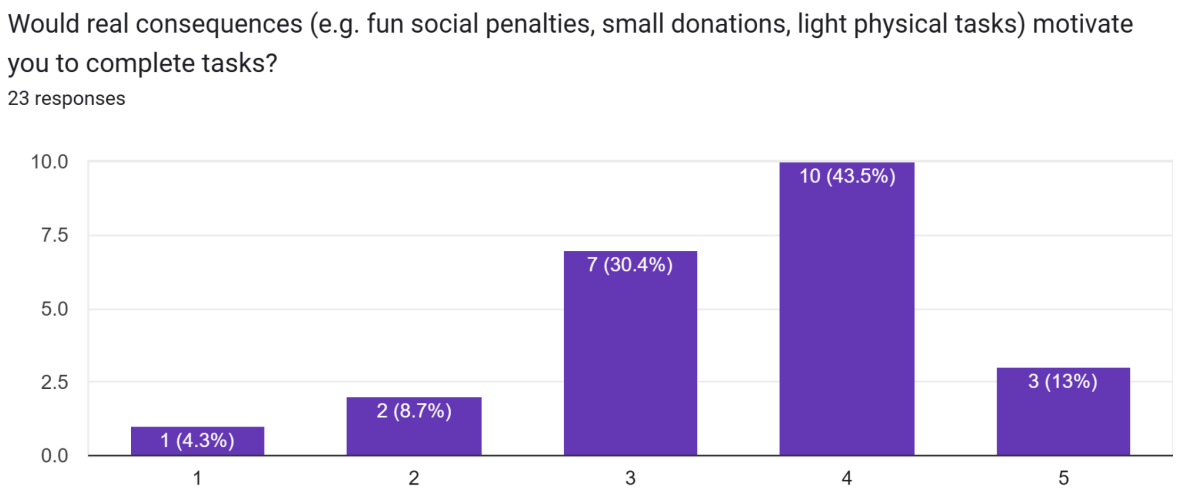


Figure 10. Survey result on whether or not real-consequences motivates you to complete task

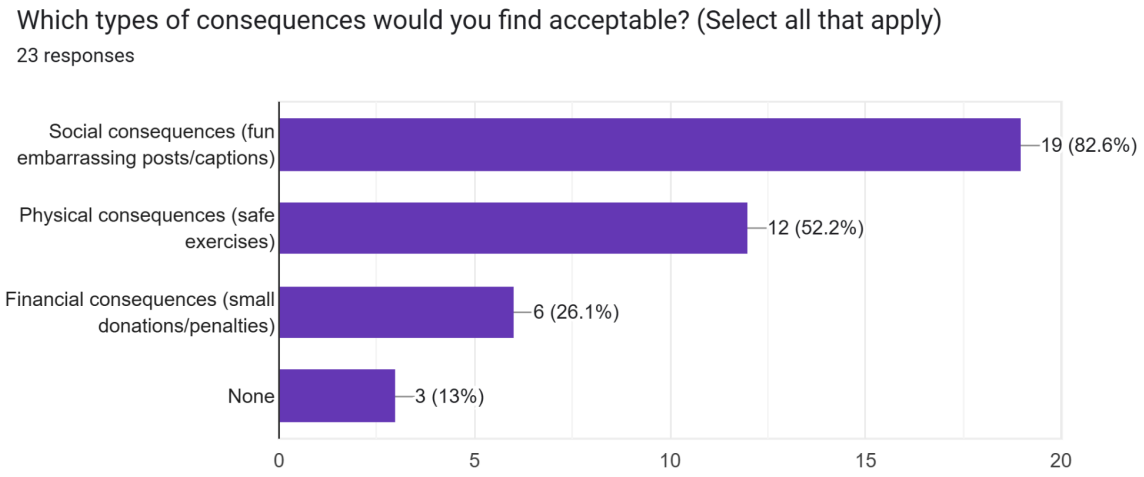


Figure 11. Survey result on which type of consequence is more acceptable

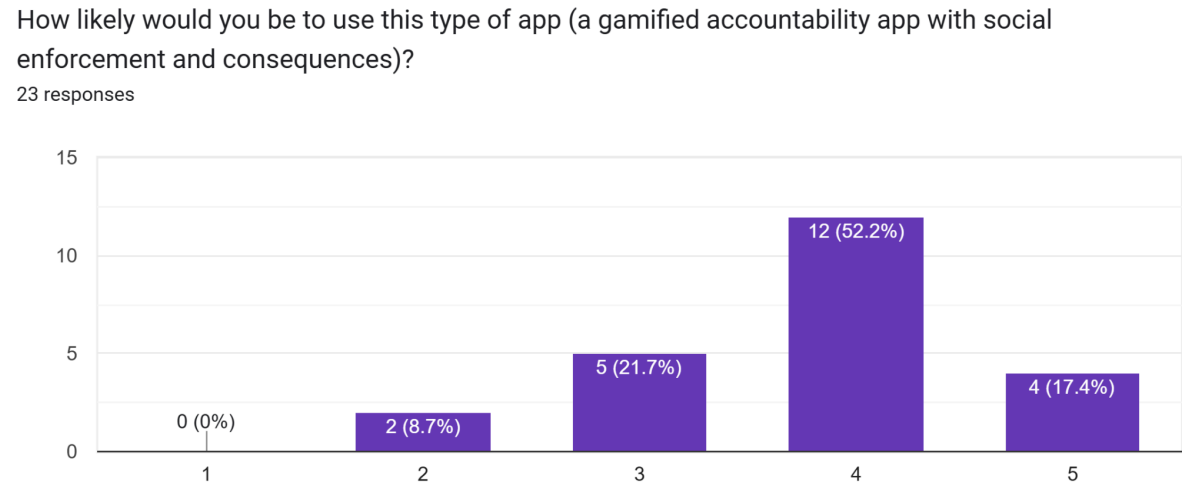


Figure 12. Survey result on whether they would use this kind of app

For the last question which was open-ended, there were a few common themes from the responses, mainly suggesting the idea that they were more likely to use the app if there were rewards also included alongside the punishments, if their friends were also using the app, and if it was easy to use/can be integrated into their daily routine. From all the responses for the survey, there is a clear desirability for the app we are proposing. Firstly, most respondents have struggled with staying consistent and being motivated, and what currently motivates them the most is social pressure. In regards to the social aspect of the app, most of the respondents agreed that having friends hold them accountable would improve their habits and consistency, and were for the most part also okay with sharing their habit progress with their friends. Another point is that they also think that some consequences could help motivate them to complete their tasks, with the most preferred punishment being social consequences that are more lighthearted. Finally, there is a positive reception to using

a gamified system to help motivate them to use the app, and overall there is decent interest in using our proposed app if it were to be implemented.

Feasibility

- Qualifications: Experience making a full stack web/mobile application from CS203 class in the previous semester. Some members are also taking CS461 learning about Mobile Computing & Applications to assist with making the product.
- Required: Basic/standard mobile and web application components such as user authentication, database management, server-side processing, media handling, etc.

The project can be done in a modular manner, starting with the simpler/core features such as user authentication, task creation, etc. and scaling into more advanced features such as AI integration and potential robust coin system. Challenges may arise in the later stages, where we start to implement the aforementioned advanced features. Ensuring system scalability and maintaining data privacy/security can also be a real challenge since we have little experience, but through modular development and smart design, it should not significantly hinder the development of the app.

Viability

Existing competition includes other productivity apps such as:

- Habitica - similar gamification but doesn't enforce real-world consequences
- Beeminder - attaches real-world consequences, but no social accountability aspect
- Streaks - focuses more on personal/internal consistency but no social accountability & real-world consequences
- StickK - "Commitment Contract" with a goal and a referee. If you fail to reach your goal, your money is donated to a charity of your choice, or for higher stakes a charity or political organization you dislike.

The market gap lies in the absence of socially enforced accountability. Most other apps focus on reminders or tracking progress individually but few actually make social circles enforce that accountability. The punishment aspect is also a unique feature of the app that helps it stand out among other more traditional habit-tracking and productivity apps.

Primarily the target market will be university students and Gen Z individuals seeking socially enforced accountability tools, who tend to respond more positively to gamified experiences and can benefit from external pressure as a motivator. The potential size of the total market can likely reach a global market composed of students/young adults interested in a new form of motivation for self-improvement and productivity. Estimated costs come mainly from cloud hosting for server infrastructure and data storage. Depending on the AI integration and other additional features, we could also incur costs from API usage and integration and as the user base grows, operational costs relating to performance optimization and data security will also increase. For the estimated revenue, the app can use a freemium business model

like other similar apps that use a system of subscriptions and in-app purchases that gives access to more advanced and personalized features.This model would support a sustainable revenue generation scheme while also keeping a low barrier to entry for new users.